

## MEETING THE PAIN OF DESTRUCTIVE PATTERNS

Greetings, my dearest friends. God bless each one of you. Blessed is this hour.

Most of my friends who work on this path at this time approach a certain area of their soul problems in which they encounter pain. In order to understand the meaning of this pain, I should like to give you an overall view of the process for dissolving this pain and for resolving, as well, your inner problems and conflicts. Some of what I say is in repetition of the long drawn out work we have done together in these years, but I shall attempt to give you a comprehensive view of the entire process of work. Such understanding will help toward the further resolution of conflicts and enable you to cope with the afflicted area of your psyche.

First, let us briefly recapitulate. To begin with, the child suffers from certain imperfections of the parents' love and affection. It also suffers out of not being fully accepted in its own individuality. By this, I mean the common practice of treating a child as a child rather than as a particular individual. From this, you suffer although you may never be aware of it in these terms or in exact thoughts. This may leave as much of a scar as the lack of love or of attention. It causes as many frustrations as does the lack of love, or even cruelty.

This general climate in which you grow up affects you like a constant minor shock that often leaves more of a mark than one traumatic shocking experience. That is why the latter is so often easier to cure than the former. The constant climate of nonacceptance of your individuality, as well as the lack of love and understanding, cause that which is called a neurosis. You take this climate as a matter of course. You take it for granted. You believe that it has to be so. Nevertheless, you suffer from it. And the combination of suffering from it and believing it to be unalterable fact conditions you to develop destructive defenses.

This original pain and frustration that the child cannot deal with is repressed. It is put out of awareness, but it smolders in the unconscious mind. It is then that the destructive images and defense mechanisms begin to form. In the past, we have gone into these various defense mechanisms rather extensively. The images that you create are defense mechanisms. For, in their wrong conclusion, you seek a way of fighting against the unwelcome factors that have created the original pain. The pseudosolutions are a way of battling the world, the pain, and all of that which you wish to avoid.

When your pseudosolution is a withdrawal from feeling, from loving and from living, it is a defense against being hurt. Only after considerable insight into yourself will you see what an unrealistic, shortsighted "remedy" this is. You will want to change and would rather welcome the pain than the self-alienation of feeling nothing, or so very little. After continued work and courageously going through the temporary periods of discouragement and resistance, you will come

to the point when this hard shell breaks down and you are no longer dead inside. But the first reaction will not be pleasant. It cannot be. All the repressed negative emotions, as well as the repressed pain, will at first come into awareness, and it will then seem to you that your withdrawal was right. Only after plowing ahead will you have the reward of good, constructive feelings. But about this, we shall talk in greater detail a little later.

When your pseudosolution is submissiveness, weakness, helplessness, dependency as a means toward having someone care for you -- not necessarily materially, but emotionally -- it is equally shortsighted and unsatisfactory as a solution. The constant dependency on others creates fear and helplessness. It further diminishes your already existing lack of belief in yourself. As the withdrawal solution makes you dead in feeling and robs you of the meaningfulness of life, so does the submissive solution rob you of independence and strength and creates no less isolation than the former although it does so through a different inner road. Originally you wished to avoid the pain by providing yourself with a strong person to care for you. Only you inflict upon yourself more pain because you can never find such a person. That person must be yourself.

By making yourself deliberately weak, as it were, you exert the strongest tyranny over others. There is no stronger tyranny than that which a weak person exerts over the stronger or upon his entire environment. It is as though he is constantly saying: "I am so weak. You have to help me. I am so helpless. You are responsible for me. The mistakes I commit do not count because I do not know any better. I cannot help it. You must constantly be indulgent with me and allow me to get away with everything. I cannot be expected to take full responsibility for my actions or the lack of them, for my thoughts and feelings or for the lack of them. I may fail because I am weak. You are strong; therefore you must understand everything. You cannot have any failures because your failures would affect me." The self-indulgent, lazy, self-pity of the weak exerts stringent demands on their fellow creatures. This becomes evident if the unspoken expectancy, the meaning of emotional reactions are investigated and then interpreted into concise thought.

It is fallacious to think that the weak person is harmless and hurts others less than, let us say, the outright domineering and aggressive person. All pseudosolutions bring untold pain to the self as well as to others. By withdrawing, you reject others and withhold from them the love you want to give them and that they want to receive from you. By submitting, you do not love, but merely expect to be loved. You do not see that others, too, have their vulnerabilities and weaknesses and needs. You reject all that part of their human nature, and thus hurt them. By the aggressive solution, you push people from you and openly hurt them with false superiority. In all instances, you hurt others and thus inflict further hurt upon yourself because the hurt you inflict cannot help but bring consequences. Thus the pseudosolutions, intended to eliminate the original pain, only bring you more of it.

All of these pseudosolutions, in addition to various other aspects, are incorporated into your idealized self-image. Since the nature of the idealized self-image is self-aggrandizement, it separates you from others. Since its nature is separateness, it isolates you and makes you and those you deal with lonely. Since its nature is falsity and pretense, it alienates you from yourself, from life, and from others. All of that is bound to bring you pain, hurt, frustration, unfulfillment. You chose a way out of pain and frustration, but this way has proven not only inadequate, but it actually brings you much more of that which you wished to forego. However, to clearly recognize this fact and to put the links together requires the active work of sincere self-search.

The perfectionism that is so deeply ingrained in you and in your idealized self-image makes it impossible for you to accept yourself and others, to accept life in its reality; and you are therefore incapable of coping with it and resolving its problems and your own problems as well. It causes you to forego the experience of living in the true sense.

Most of you, my friends, have dealt with all these levels and aspects of yourself. You have come across many recognitions and insights that dealt with your wrong conclusions, misconceptions, images, pseudosolutions. You are, to some extent at least, aware of the particular nature of your particular idealized self-image. You have some inkling as to the way in which you are self-alienated and in what respect your perfectionism exists. You have therefore realized the extent of damage you inflicted upon yourself and upon others and have seen how unsatisfactory these pseudodefenses and protections are. You may not all be fully aware of all these factors, but most of you are sufficiently aware of them to be inwardly ready to give them up. Some of you have actually reached the threshold opening the way to a new inner life, of emotional willingness to let go of all these defenses. Others too will approach this phase quite soon, provided they continue in their work with inner willingness. The mere exercise of constantly observing the unrealistic and immature emotions and reactions weakens their impact and begins a process of dissolving them automatically, so to speak. When a certain dissolution has taken place, the psyche is ready to cross the threshold. But the act of crossing it, in the beginning, is a painful one.

You would expect, when crossing this important threshold, that the new, constructive patterns can immediately replace the old destructive ones. Such an expectation is unrealistic and not according to truth. Such constructive patterns cannot have a solid foundation before you experience and go through the original pain and frustration and all that which you ran away from. That which you turned away from has to be faced, felt, experienced, understood, coped with, come to terms with, and assimilated before the unhealthy and unrealistic is dissolved, the immature matured, the healthy but repressed forces brought into their proper channels so as to work constructively for you. The longer you delay this painful process, the more difficult and lasting is it bound to be whenever you are ready to pass from childhood into adulthood. Even if you die in this life as a child, at one period or another of your spiritual development, this threshold has to be crossed. This pain is a healthy growing pain, and the light is in sight if and when you overcome your resistance to delay the process. The strength, the self-reliance, and the capacity to live fully with all your constructive patterns beginning to work, is ample compensation for all the years of destructive and unproductive living as well as for the pain of crossing the threshold into emotional adulthood.

How can you imagine being spared experiencing the pain for which you instituted the destructive patterns? Their purpose was to run away from something that occurred in your life -- actual or imaginary makes little difference. It is this very wishful thinking process of running away and looking away from something that is or was, thus not facing and coping with your reality, that caused your soul sickness. Hence it is this area that has to be tackled now. This is why those of you who have made your first tentative steps over the threshold (there may be occasional relapses, for no inner process develops in just one smooth action) are puzzled by the acute pain you experience. Often you do not quite understand why this is so. You may have some vague idea and some partial answers, but this lecture will help you to derive a more profound understanding of the reason.

Intellectually you all know that this path is not a fairy tale in which you find your deviations and misconceptions and evasions, and after having done so, nothing but bliss follows. In the last analysis, it is true, of course, that being freed of your shackles of error and deviation is bound to bring you happiness. But until you reach that stage, there are many areas of your soul that have to be experienced until such time as your psyche is truly equipped to make the best of life. Even after the acute pain has been properly dealt with and is no longer present, the unrealistic, although often unconscious, expectation exists that now life will always grant you what you wish. No, my friends; however, the reality is much better. In reality, you will learn to cope with the mishaps and difficulties rather than becoming broken by them. You will not fortify your destructive defenses. This in turn will equip you with the tools to make the best out of each opportunity, derive the maximum of benefit and happiness out of every experience of life.

Needless to say, this is never done with your destructive defense mechanisms and various images. Let me repeat here what I have often said, first the outer negative events will continue to come your way as a result of your past ingrained patterns. But you will encounter them in a different way. As you learn to do so, you will become aware of many opportunities for happiness that you were blind to in the past. In this way, you begin to change the patterns until very, very gradually, perhaps over a process of several incarnations, the unhappy outer events cease more and more. But when you find yourself at the beginning of this stage, do not expect immediate fulfillment and happiness in every respect. Do not expect that it comes from the outside without your making it so by learning and experiencing in the productive way; by seeing your possibilities and opportunities; by strengthening your intuition, your self-reliance resourcefulness and independent ability to choose, instead of being utterly helpless and waiting for fate to bring you happiness.

By now, you must understand how in many respects you have caused your own unhappiness by and through your own destructive, unrealistic evasions and defenses. So will you now realize and gain from it a sense of strength that you can bring about your own fulfillment and happiness. Again, this cannot be done by intellectual understanding. It is an inner process that grows organically. As you now deeply understand that no unkind fate or cruel god has punished or neglected you, so will you deeply understand and know that it is you who can create all the fulfillment your soul craves for, which craving you were not even conscious of when you first began this path. This consciousness may have come only after the fuller understanding of all your pseudosolutions and misconceptions, from the depths of which you become aware of your needs. The primary result on this path is the understanding of your own cause and effect and of the sense of strength, independence, self-reliance, and justice that this gives to an individual. How much time it takes to reach the first tentative beginnings of this new strength, and later the strengthening of it, depends on your efforts, your inner will, and your overcoming the ever present resistance which wears off only after you gain sufficient recognition of its devious ways.

Now, my friends, when you come across this pain, is it really merely the pain you once experienced as a child? Is it really the frustration the child suffered from the parents, and nothing more? No, my friends, this is not entirely correct. It is true that this original pain and frustration has afflicted the resiliency of your psyche and thus made you incapable of properly dealing with it. It caused you to turn away from it and look for unsatisfactory "solutions." But the pain you now experience is much more the present pain of unfulfillment caused by the unproductive patterns. Consciously you cannot distinguish this. You may not even be aware of the original childhood pain.

It may take time and self-observation to distinguish the pain at all. After you do so, the more acute pain is your despair with yourself and with life now, not in the past. The past is important only because it caused you to institute the unproductive ways responsible for your present pain.

If you do not shy away from it, but go through it, becoming aware of its significance, you will realize that your present unfulfilled needs cause the pain. Your frustration will be your inability, at this time, to bring about fulfillment. You cannot as yet see what you can do about it. You feel caught in your own trap, not seeing how to get out of it, thus being dependent on outer intervention over which you have no control. Only after courageously making all these impressions and reactions become aware will you gradually see a way out, and thereby decrease your helplessness, and increase your independent strength and resourcefulness.

In a previous lecture, we discussed the human needs. Before you uncover your various "protective layers," you cannot even be fully aware of your real needs. You may know some of your unreal, superimposed needs, but only after a fuller understanding of yourself do you gradually become aware of the basic, naked needs that you have held in check. When you experience the pain, before crossing the threshold into emotional maturity and productive patterns, you have the possibility, if you so choose, to become precisely aware of these needs. This is inevitable if you wish to come out of your present state of unproductive living.

As you go through the process of becoming aware of your needs and the frustration of their unfulfillment, you will find first the stringent need to be loved -- just as the child needs to receive love and affection. However, it cannot be said that the need to be loved is childish and immature. It is only so when the adult person has locked his soul and refused to grow in his own capacity to give love so that the need to receive remains isolated as well as covered. Through your destructive patterns, you pushed your painful need to receive into the unconscious. Due to this unawareness, as also to the defense mechanisms of various sorts, your ability to give could never grow within your psyche.

However, during your past endeavors, during all the work you have done, you have not only become aware of so much that was hidden away, but, as I said before, you have begun to dissolve certain destructive levels. This has, as it were, inadvertently caused your ability to give love to come into being even though you may not yet be fully aware of it. As you encounter the pain, what actually goes on in you is the tremendous pressure of these needs. On the one hand, you face the need to receive which is ungratified so long as the destructive patterns prevail. It requires some time to be able to institute the productive patterns to gain the necessary strength and resourcefulness to find the way to bring about fulfillment of this need to receive. On the other hand, the need to give cannot find an outlet until this stage is reached. Thus a double frustration is caused -- and this causes tremendous pressure. It is this pressure that is so painful. It seems to tear you apart.

However, do not believe, my friends, that this pressure, this entire frustration did not exist before you became aware of it. It did exist, but it created other outlets, perhaps in physical sickness or in many other symptoms. As you become aware of the central core, the pressure and pain may feel more acute, but this must be the healing process. You thus draw your awareness to the central cause where the problem really lies. You focus your attention upon that which is the root. You shift your emphasis from the evasion to the reality. This reality pain has to be experienced in all its shades and variety. You have to become aware of what your needs are exactly: to give and to

receive; the frustration of not finding an outlet; the accumulated pressure; the momentary helplessness of finding relief; the temptation to evade again as you have done in the past. As you battle through this phase, as you strengthen your will to no longer run away from yourself and from the apparent risk of living, opportunities will come your way. You will see them and make use of them. They will teach you to further your growth and strength until your needs can find partial fulfillment, and then little by little, there will be an increase in the measure that you grow and change your patterns.

You must understand that at this period you find yourself at an interim stage. You have become aware of your need to receive, which is in itself healthy. But this need has become exaggeratedly strong and therefore immature because of your repression of it and the thus resulting frustration of the healthy fulfillment of receiving. If you do not sufficiently receive, the demand grows out of proportion, all the more so when you are unconscious of this stringent demand.

Simultaneously, due to your progress and to the growth that has taken place within you, the mature need to give has grown. You could not find an outlet for this because the destructive patterns were still in effect, perhaps only partly so, perhaps modified. You may even have begun attempts to compromise between the old and the new desired way. However, do not forget that effective results can come only when patterns become an integral and almost automatic reaction in you. Your old patterns have been in existence for years, decades, and often for longer -- going through several lifetimes in which you battled with the same problems and always shied away from facing them, facing yourself, and facing life as it is. Now as you learn to do so and have begun to change, outer change does not come at once while inner change has begun to work. In this period, the pressure inside may become most stringent. However, if you realize all this and have the courage to go through it, you are bound to come out a stronger, happier person, better equipped to live in the true sense of the word. Beware of turning back and into evasion all over again. Do not believe that this temporary period in which you encounter all the accumulated inner pressure with the accompanying helplessness, inadequacy, and confusion is the final result. It is the tunnel through which you must pass, my friends.

After you do so, your sense of strength, adequacy, and your own resourcefulness will grow steadily -- with occasional relapses, of course -- but if you make each relapse serve as a further steppingstone, further lesson, the new patterns will eventually establish themselves in your inner being and will make you see the possibilities you have overlooked for so long. You will then have the courage to take these possibilities instead of rejecting them in fear. Thus and thus only will the fulfillment come.

It is so important for you to understand that and to deeply absorb it, my friends. If you do, it must help you. Is that clear, my friends? Are there any questions regarding this subject?

QUESTION: When I go through certain phases of various fears, is that connected with the subject you discussed tonight?

ANSWER: Yes, it is indeed. Fears are so often a subterfuge of the basic core of pain. They come into existence as a result of your evasion, just as other symptoms are such a consequence. In this work, you have often noticed that, after certain progress, the fears begin to vanish more and more, and then you become aware of the pain. The fear is an inadvertent result of the evasion that

was not deliberately chosen, of course. But all evasion must have more unpleasant results than the original core. Unpleasant as the original pain may be, once one accepts truth, it is so much better, so much easier, so much more honest and healthy than any result of evasion, be it fear or anything else. Since fear vanishes only after it is faced, met, and come to terms with, pain, the underlying cause of it, has to be dealt with similarly.

However, it is not only the pain of unfulfillment that you cringe away from. It is also mature self-responsibility that you do not want to take upon yourself. This may not at all apply to your outer material life, but may affect the emotional plane -- if you do not wish to love and live in the fear of being hurt, if you do not wish to take the risk of living upon yourself. In that sense, you wish to remain the child who waits helplessly for life to fulfill his needs without the necessity of self-involvement. The price you pay for such evasion is very high. Many of you do not yet realize how high that price is. This running away from self-responsibility and the apparent risk of living and feeling is caused by an original sense of inadequacy, and it steadily increases that sense of inadequacy. Only as you change this pattern will you find your sense of adequacy and self-confidence. This is based on the same psychic law that the running away from the original pain of unfulfillment increases the unfulfillment and therefore the pain.

QUESTION: In the process of my work of late, I occasionally felt the need to give love and not only to receive. But this feeling goes away again. How can I learn to always feel the need to give?

ANSWER: My dear friend, it would be very misleading to say you learn it. This is something you cannot learn by a voluntary act. If you should attempt it, it amounts to a manipulation of your feelings, and in the last analysis, it would be dishonest. If it is real, it happens naturally and by itself, as you have already noticed it. This will come more often and last longer and become stronger, but only if you do not force it directly. The best way to get to this point of growth, maturity, and productive living is by simply observing your emotions. Note how they are still geared to the one-sided, childish desire to merely receive. The more you observe yourself in objective evaluation, the more will you find the underlying causes for such an imbalance, the more will you speed the process of growth that finally will enable you not only to experience the need to give as much as to receive love but eventually also to find the necessary outlet.

I must repeat again and again that inner growth cannot happen suddenly. First you have a glimpse, a momentary experience of a new way of feeling. Then it goes away again. If, at such a time, you are not discouraged and do not give way to the feeling that it is of no use because you have apparently relapsed into the old way, but persevere instead, the periods of healthy, good feeling will come more often and will last longer. Each relapse seems to lead you to the same old tunnel, but it does not. It is a new one, and this knowledge will not discourage you. If you pass through it, the momentary glimpse of strength, love, and light will come again until it finally becomes a part of you.

QUESTION: I discovered in my work that, mixed in with healthy and productive pleasure, is also destructive or self-destructive pleasure. The latter can't always be recognized as such and is difficult to get rid of. There seems to be a confusion between the pleasure principle and rejection, as well as between happiness and selfishness. What can you suggest?

ANSWER: Apart from the question of masochism I have gone into considerably in the past, and also in an answer to a recent question, I have this to say. Here the either/or attitude of the child prevails. The child in you feels that if you are in pursuit of pleasure, you are not in reality. Reality means rejection and unpleasure, therefore you escape from it and build your pleasure in fantasy. This then seems to confirm the contention that reality and pleasure are incompatible. To a lesser degree, this can be found in every human being, but to a greater extent it is found in emotional and mental illness. If, to begin with, this misconception would not exist, if one knew that reality is not only rejection but also pleasure, one would not need to seek the pleasure only in unreality. This is the confusion. By the same token, the confusion between happiness and selfishness is based on the same principle of either/or. The child in you feels that if you are happy, you must be selfish, while all unselfishness automatically goes against your interest and gratification. Needless to say, this is not so in reality. Only the inner process of growth through which you are going will give you the inner understanding and conviction that happiness and unselfishness are not incompatible.

QUESTION: You discussed in the last lecture that the effect of one person being in truth about himself is of greater cosmic importance than we can possibly realize. Can you explain this?

ANSWER: If you think for a moment of the effect of the negative, distorted soul parts of a human being in the sense again discussed tonight, you will also understand the opposite. Any pseudosolution, as I indicated tonight, is bound to reject another human being. When you submit, you do not experience the truth of the other person's humanity, of his needs, of his vulnerabilities, of his own problems, and his insecurity. In your demand to possess a strong and ever loving protector, you must be disappointed, perhaps unconsciously so, and in your disappointment, you become hostile -- perhaps again unconsciously. When you are aggressively arrogant, denying your own need to find love, affection, communication, you outrightly reject the other person. In your withdrawal, you never give warmth, you never fulfill the other person's needs. When you are self-alienated and perfectionistic, you cannot help but hurt others. When the pretense of your idealized self is at work, you do not let another person come near you in the unconscious fear of facing exposure, and you are bound over and over again to reject him, perhaps without ever realizing that you are doing so. All this rejection, isolation, and pain that you inadvertently inflict onto others is bound to strengthen their own destructive defense mechanisms, just as their destructive defenses fortify your own. This persists unless you are on such a path and begin to see the process for what it is.

Now reverse the process. Imagine the effect it must have on your surroundings when you are no longer defensive, fearful, withdrawn, falsely superior. You are then open to life, to the heart of another person. The courage to live and to love enables you to help another person weaken his own defenses and destructive patterns even if he is not yet developed far enough to choose such a path of self-finding. Everyone you come into contact with is therefore affected. And this effect extends over all those whom they in turn come into contact with. It draws rings upon rings of effect and intereffect. If you think about it in these terms, you are bound to visualize the truth.

My dearest friends, be blessed, each one of you. May these words be a further key and a help for your continued growth and liberation. May they help you to become yourself, to be in full possession of the individual you are, with all the resources, the strength, the ingenuity, the creativity, and love force that is inherent in you, waiting to be allowed to function freely. Be in peace. Be in God!



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